

Norauto — Deep Research Report

Prepared for: Chief Technology Officer, Norauto International

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1. Company at a glance

Norauto was founded near Lille in 1970 and created the auto-centre format: a retail store combined with a multi-brand workshop. It is the flagship banner of Mobivia, the family-owned group headquartered at Villeneuve-d'Ascq. Norauto International exists as a distinct legal entity, a French SAS registered at Sainghin-en-Mélantois since a partial asset transfer in 2007 — a detail worth confirming early, because the perimeter of that entity is what defines the attendee's actual authority.

Mobivia's 2025 extra-financial declaration, published in February 2026, gives the group picture as at 30 September 2025: roughly 2,000 auto centres and stores across 16 countries under 14 brands including Norauto, Midas, Carter-Cash, Exadis, Vroomly and Synchro Diffusion, serving around 30 million unique customers a year with 23,200 employees. Total turnover including branches, franchises and master franchises is €4 billion; on a consolidated IFRS basis, covering integrated companies only, revenue is €3.4 billion with current operating profit of €154 million and cash of €235 million. The group estimates it reaches around 5% of the European vehicle parc through its networks. Ownership remains familial, with employee shareholding at 2.3% of capital.

The physical and logistics footprint matters for anyone running systems across it: six logistics warehouses in France, Spain, Italy, Germany and Sweden feeding the networks from regional hubs, more than 1,200 referenced suppliers, and 86% of employees in direct customer contact. Around €65 million was invested in stores and workshops during the year.

In France, Norauto runs about 410 centres handling roughly three million entries a year. Its own-label range, sold since 1994, now generates more than €500 million a year — around 35% of the banner's sales — and is designed by a team of about ten people under Jérôme Carrodano covering France, Benelux, Italy, Spain and Portugal. Norauto opened its Villeneuve-d'Ascq innovation centre to press for the first time on 3 June 2026, unusual for a group that is normally reticent about internal operations.

Romain Sartorius has been Mobivia's chairman and chief executive since February 2024. Mobivia sold a majority stake in Norauto Argentina to Stellantis in July 2023, a documented narrowing of the brand's direct geographic perimeter.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which technology decisions sit with Norauto International, which with country businesses, and which with Mobivia group functions?
- Which markets and legal entities are inside your perimeter when you say Norauto International?
- How much of the centre network in your remit is directly operated versus franchised?

2. Strategic direction

Mobivia's stated position is that mobility is essential for everyone and that the group's job is to keep people sustainably mobile. In practice the 2025 reporting frames three things: making maintenance and repair more affordable and more geographically accessible, developing employee skills, and reducing the environmental impact of motoring.

Digital is already material rather than aspirational: 18% of group activity now comes through digital channels. The group describes an explicitly omnichannel value chain joining online sales, workshops, stores, purchasing, logistics, technical innovation and data services — which is the operative point for a technology function, because the promise only holds if all six of those move together.

Circularity has been industrialised rather than marketed. The group reports 10.4% of revenue classified as positive-impact under its own internal framework, an eco-score reference being deployed to steer the offer, three industrial sites and 24 recycling channels covering waste streams from servicing and repair. The dedicated entities are iWip for automotive waste collection and sorting, Black-Star and ESTATO for material and product recovery, and Tyval as the linked eco-organisation. Black-Star has recently been placed in safeguard proceedings, which is a live commercial fact rather than a footnote.

The B2B channel is a stated priority. More than 350,000 professional vehicles were serviced in Norauto centres in 2024, against fleet segments running from one to fifty vehicles up to fleets above 800, and Mobivia has built a European fleet partnership platform to support it. Professional customers bring different data, contracting and integration requirements than retail customers.

On skills, 1,450 employees were trained in electronics during the year, with an internal school for electrotechnicians and mechatronics. More than 70% of Midas centres are certified to work on electric and hybrid vehicles; Mobivia does not publish an equivalent certification rate for the other banners.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which business outcomes define success for the international technology agenda this year?
- Where does Norauto want common international capability, and where is country variation deliberate?
- How are digital channel targets reconciled against workshop capacity?

3. Industry forces

The fleet is ageing and complicating at the same time. That combination sustains maintenance demand while raising the technical floor: an older combustion parc alongside a growing electric and hybrid one means more diagnostic variety, more calibration, more high-voltage work and more dependence on manufacturer technical data — all of which arrive as systems and data requirements before they arrive as workshop requirements.

Parts procurement is moving online decisively, and the clearest evidence is competitive rather than analytical. AUTODOC reported that more than half of independent garages in France are already connected to its professional platform, and grew first-half 2026 revenue 12.8% to just over €1 billion. Price transparency in parts erodes the traditional protection that came from being the only party who knew what a job should cost.

Skilled labour is the binding constraint on capacity. Mobivia's own reporting shows the pressure: permanent employee turnover and the scale of electronics retraining are both disclosed, and more than 130 nationalities across a workforce that is 86% customer-facing. A workshop network cannot scale digital demand faster than it can staff and certify bays.

Emissions sit overwhelmingly upstream. Mobivia reports that purchases account for more than three-quarters of group emissions, ahead of product use, freight, energy and travel, while Scope 1 emissions fell 1.5% and renewable energy in consumption rose 9%. That distribution means decarbonisation reporting depends on supplier and product data the group does not itself generate.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which fleet transition is creating the most operational change today — ageing vehicles, hybrids, EVs, ADAS or connected data access?
- Where is parts price transparency hurting most: margin, conversion, or the conversation in the centre?
- Which capability shortage is most restrictive: workshop skills, digital product skills, data skills or security?

4. Regulatory and compliance frame

Four regimes converge on this role, and three of them are about data rather than vehicles.

Repair access and competition. Regulation (EU) 461/2010, amended by Regulation 2023/822, governs qualifying spare-parts and repair agreements until 31 May 2028, with accompanying guidelines extending competition principles to vehicle-generated data. Regulation 2018/858 governs access to onboard diagnostics and repair and maintenance information. For an independent network, access to that information is a commercial precondition, not a compliance

topic.

Data access. The EU Data Act has applied since 12 September 2025, giving users greater control over data generated by connected products including vehicles, and allowing them to share it with independent repair and maintenance providers while preserving privacy and trade-secret protection. This is potentially the most consequential item on the list, because it changes what an independent network can obtain about a customer's vehicle — and creates an obligation to handle that data lawfully once obtained.

Circularity. Regulation 2023/1542 covers the full battery lifecycle. The End-of-Life Vehicles Regulation, Regulation (EU) 2026/1738, was published on 24 July 2026 and entered into force on 13 August 2026, but generally applies only from 1 September 2028, with the existing ELV Directive governing until then and several requirements phased later still. LKQ Europe has publicly argued that its significance for the independent aftermarket is larger than the name suggests, because it explicitly prioritises reuse, remanufacturing, refurbishment and repair over disposal — which, if it works, expands the reusable-parts supply an independent network can sell.

Consumer protection and privacy. EU consumer law governs pre-contract information, cancellation rights, guarantees and price indications; Directive 2024/825, applying from 27 September 2026, adds controls on durability, repairability and environmental claims — directly relevant to how an eco-score or a positive-impact classification can be presented to customers. GDPR applies across customer, employee and vehicle-linked data. Mobivia additionally identifies French AGEC extended-producer-responsibility regimes for oils and tyres, Sapin II anti-corruption controls and duty-of-vigilance processes in its compliance frame.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which of these consumes the most technology and data-management effort today?
- Has the Data Act changed what you can obtain from vehicles, or is it still theoretical in practice?
- Who owns evidence collection when one obligation spans countries, brands, suppliers and franchisees?

5. The technology leader's world at Norauto

Two things define the shape of this role, and both are unusual.

The first is that Norauto International has already been through a full commerce replatform. In 2022 the company began deploying a cloud omnichannel platform across roughly 4,000 tills in around 1,200 centres in seven countries, replacing a system — Winshop among its components — that teams had used for two decades. Whatever the current state of that estate, the organisation

has recent institutional memory of what a multi-country core system change costs in change management terms, and that memory shapes what it will and will not attempt next. Norauto has also migrated its French network to SD-WAN with Orange Business, covering several hundred sites, with in-workshop screens showing customers live maintenance progress cited as one of the intended uses.

The second is that Mobivia does not have a single AI posture, and this is on the record from inside the group. Alexandre Douchez, digital commerce director at Carter-Cash, said publicly in July 2026 that Norauto and ATU are doing more and more with artificial intelligence while Carter-Cash has deliberately chosen not to — building out a human call centre instead, handling more than 8,000 conversations a day with around fifty people through a Tunisian provider, on the argument that in a technical category where a wrong part fits a wrong vehicle, human advice beats price. He describes Carter-Cash as being invited to follow the same path as its sister brands and Mobivia as respecting the divergence because it is working.

That is a rare thing to have documented: sister brands in one group taking opposite positions on the same technology, with group tolerance for the difference. For a CTO whose remit spans an international brand inside that group, it defines the real question — not whether to adopt, but how much convergence the group actually wants, and who decides.

The technical estate itself carries the sector's characteristic problem: a digital promise only pays out when the right part, the right technician, the right bay, the right vehicle identification and the right authorisation are available at the same moment. Vehicle identification is the pivot. Get it wrong and the error propagates into parts selection, pricing, booking and workshop execution before anyone notices.

Questions to ask on the day:

- What did the omnichannel replatform teach you about multi-country change, and what would you do differently?
- Norauto and Carter-Cash have visibly different AI positions. How much convergence does the group actually want?
- Where does vehicle identification break today, and what does that cost downstream?
- What proportion of your attention goes to operational reliability versus new capability?

6. Peer signals

AUTODOC is the sharpest competitive signal and it just changed direction. Having built a hybrid model combining a digital platform with local service agents, it announced in June 2026 that it was abandoning that approach for AUTODOC PRO and moving to a fully digital B2B operating model

in most countries, streamlining operations including returns and pushing professional interactions onto the platform. Its results support the confidence: first-half 2026 revenue of €1,003.4 million, up 12.8%, adjusted EBITDA of €91.9 million, up 13.7%, and 9.3 million active customers with 18.9 million orders across 2025. In France, it says more than half of independent garages are connected to PRO. It has also opened a 15,000 square metre warehouse in Ghent serving France and Benelux.

Halfords is the closest structural comparison, being a retail-plus-workshop business rather than a parts platform, and its most useful disclosure is which half is growing. For the 53 weeks to 3 April 2026 it reported like-for-like sales growth of 4.8% with a stable operating margin, and its CFO noted that workshop was among the best-performing categories on like-for-like growth, ahead of the wider retail business. Its Fit for the Future strategy, set out in November 2025, sequences an optimise phase before evolve and scale.

LKQ Europe is the voice worth listening to on the regulatory side, having publicly analysed what the ELV Regulation means for independent repair and remanufacturing, and is building EV-certified workshop networks, technical support, training, garage management software and parts logistics as a combined proposition.

The convergent pattern across all three is that differentiation has moved from any single channel to the quality of the connection between demand generation, technical data, parts logistics and workshop execution. AUTODOC's retreat from the hybrid model is a useful counterpoint: it concluded that trying to be both digital and physical in B2B was not efficient. Norauto's whole model is the opposite bet.

Questions to ask on the day:

- AUTODOC just concluded that hybrid B2B does not pay. What makes Norauto's version different?
- Halfords reports workshop outgrowing retail. Does your data say the same, and can you see it cleanly?
- Which peer capability do you regard as genuinely differentiated rather than well-marketed?

7. Friction map

The recurring tension is that a booking is a promise made by one system about a resource controlled by another. Online availability, parts stock, technician certification and bay capacity are maintained by different owners on different rhythms, with different levels of local variation. No single operational statement stays true unless the inputs behind it are continually reconciled — and that reconciliation is manual more often than anyone would like to admit.

Vehicle identification errors are the highest-leverage failure in this business, because the error does not stay where it happens. A wrong identification travels into parts selection, quoted price, booking duration and the work actually performed in the bay, and is usually discovered by a technician with a customer waiting.

Brand-level divergence inside the group is a structural feature rather than a bug, and it cuts both ways. It protects positions that work locally, as Carter-Cash's human-first stance demonstrates, and it makes any common international capability a negotiation rather than a deployment.

Regulatory evidence tends to be assembled after decisions rather than alongside them. Vehicle-data access rights, customer consent, repair-information entitlements and environmental claims overlap without sharing a rulebook or an owner, and much of the underlying information originates outside the technology function or outside the company.

Sustainability claims depend on data that moves. With more than three-quarters of emissions sitting in purchases, and an eco-score being deployed across the offer, the numbers behind any customer-facing environmental claim come from more than 1,200 suppliers and change over time.

Questions to ask on the day:

- Which three tensions recur monthly rather than only during major programmes?
- Which one creates the most manual checking and chasing?
- Which is visible to customers or centre teams first?

Challenge cards

Card 1 of 2

Title: The promise and the bay

The challenge: Getting a dependable view of what customers can book, what centres can actually deliver, and which parts and certified technicians are genuinely available means comparing information held by different markets, channels and operational owners. The reconciliation happens repeatedly and largely by hand.

Who feels it: The CTO owns the outcome; digital teams, centre operations, supply chain, customer service and country management all carry pieces of it, and the customer meets the gap at the counter.

Why it persists: Commerce, workshop execution and supply run at different rhythms with different degrees of local variation. Vehicle identification sits underneath all of it, and an error there

propagates into parts, pricing, duration and the work performed before anyone catches it. The recent history of replatforming across roughly 4,000 tills in around 1,200 centres in seven countries is a reminder of how expensive it is to change any part of this chain.

What solved looks like: Entering a review knowing that customer-facing promises and operational capacity describe the same position, so the discussion is about deciding rather than about whose numbers are current.

Evidence base: Mobivia describes an omnichannel value chain joining online sales, workshops, stores, purchasing, logistics, technical innovation and data services, with 18% of group activity now through digital channels, supplied from six European warehouses and more than 1,200 referenced suppliers. Norauto's French network alone handles around three million entries a year across roughly 410 centres.

Open question: Which recurring review currently requires the most manual reconciliation between digital, workshop and supply information?

Card 2 of 2

Title: How much convergence does the group want?

The challenge: Sister brands in the same group have taken publicly opposite positions on the same technology, and the group tolerates it. That leaves an international technology function without a settled answer on where common capability is expected and where local difference is protected.

Who feels it: The CTO, brand and country leadership, group functions, and every team asked to build something twice or to adopt something they did not choose.

Why it persists: The divergence is not accidental or unresolved — it reflects genuinely different commercial positions that are each working on their own terms. A discounter competing on price and a service network competing on expertise do not need identical technology. But without an explicit convergence principle, every shared platform decision reopens the argument from scratch.

What solved looks like: A stated rule for what is common by default and what is deliberately local, understood by brand leadership, so that platform decisions are applications of an agreed principle rather than fresh negotiations.

Evidence base: In July 2026 Carter-Cash's digital commerce director stated publicly that Norauto and ATU are doing more and more with AI while Carter-Cash has chosen not to, building a human call centre handling more than 8,000 conversations a day instead, and that Mobivia respects the divergence because it is delivering results. Mobivia operates 14 brands across 16 countries with roughly 2,000 sites.

Open question: When you propose a common international capability, who has to agree, and how often does that conversation end in an exception?

Where this document is thin

- No public technology strategy is attributable specifically to Norauto International.
- The CTO mandate, reporting line, budget, organisation size and division of responsibility with Mobivia group functions are not disclosed.
- No verified inventory of applications, infrastructure, cloud services or current vendors exists publicly; the 2022 omnichannel platform and the SD-WAN migration are the last documented programmes and their current state is unknown.
- Norauto's centre and employee totals were reported by the group as 631 centres including 141 franchised and 11,500 employees, but the published country list does not fully reconcile to that worldwide total.
- Country-level digital revenue, conversion, availability, incident or technology cost metrics are not published.
- Whether Norauto has an equivalent to Midas's disclosed EV and hybrid certification rate is not stated.
- No public evidence exists on Norauto's cybersecurity organisation, incident history or governance.
- A CSRD scope assessment for the Norauto International legal entity specifically, after the 2026 threshold changes, is not public.
- The group's position on vehicle data access under the Data Act — what it now obtains, from whom, and under what consent model — is not described publicly.
- The commercial and systems consequences of Black-Star's safeguard proceedings for the group's circular-economy chain are not documented.